

SAURABH SINGH



ment, telling me once: "*Siddhant kuch nahi hota, sab kuch satta ke liye hota hain. Manifesto ka cover badlata hai par mazboon kabhi nahin* (What principles are you talking about? We are all in power game. We change only the cover of the manifesto, never the subject.)" But my favourite anecdote about politicians gravitating towards new power centres is something I was witness to. In 1986, Rajiv Gandhi was having lunch with some Congress chief ministers at Parliament Annexe when his plate fell and broke. With athletic precision, a dissident chief minister quickly came up with another plate but handed him the same spoon after getting it wiped by a bearer. Remarkd another Congress chief minister, "*Rajivji, dekhiye plate toot jati hai par chamche satta ke liye ek plate se doosri plate mein chale jate hain.* (While a plate breaks, the spoon moves from one to another in search of power.)" I can go on listing examples, and all of them are not necessarily from the Congress. The charioteers of Lord Ram from BJP found nothing wrong in supping with the Dravidian parties which routinely burn Ram's effigies. George Fernandes is today the convener of NDA. Yes, the same gentleman had left the Morarji Desai government protesting against the dual membership of some former Jan Sangh members including Atal Bihari Vajpayee, under whom he later served as defence minister. One afternoon in 1979, Raj Narain and Sanjay Gandhi broke bread at the Pusa Road residence of a liquor baron in Delhi, which finally led to the fall of the Janata government in 1979. It was the same Narain who dragged Sanjay's mother Indira to

court on an election petition and later created history by defeating her in Rae Bareilly.

As I look back as a journalist who had the fortune of reporting on 12 prime ministers, I realise that the fine art of ideological compromise has been perfected at the top level. Barring Nehru, Indira and Rajiv, all of them—Charan Singh, Chandra Shekhar, V.P. Singh, Deve Gowda, Narasimha Rao, I.K. Gujral, Vajpayee and Manmohan Singh—had to forsake their ideological core for unity, and for their own stability. The Rao regime was a classic case of unity in diversity. Not a natural choice for the job after Rajiv's assassination, Rao consolidated his position by overcoming the constraints of a minority government. He was facing challenge from within as well. During one of our numerous meetings, I asked Rao why he was not getting rid of the cause of his worry, a senior minister. He explained the rationale by quoting former American president Lyndon B. Johnson who had famously said: "It is

India survives because it has mastered the art of turning many into one. Power brings the incompatible together. The Indian ruling elite is a united front.

better to have him stay indoors and piss outside, rather than kick him out so he goes out and pisses inside." It was a strategy that worked.

The strategy of survival is constantly modified according to the exigencies of power—and the ingenuity of its practitioner. As Lord Acton may have said today: power corrupts—and, more often than not, unites the corrupt. India remains united, politically as well as geographically, because our power elite had mastered the art of mergers and acquisitions long before our corporate elite did. "If the British left," Winston Churchill warned while opposing independence for India, "power will go to the hands of rascals, rogues and freebooters. All Indian leaders will be of low calibre and men of straw. They will have sweet tongues and silly hearts. They will fight among themselves for power and India will be lost in political squabbles." There have been "rogues and freebooters" but India is far from being lost. Ideology is dead. Long live the ideology of opportunism, which keeps India united. ■